UK ONLINE GROCERY

GROWTH INTELLIGENCE REPORT

Digital Performance | Paid Social Intelligence | Growth Strategy
Brands: Ocado, Sainsbury's, Tesco
Market: United Kingdom
Research period: October 2026
Project type: Independent Marketing Analytics & Growth Strategy Case Study
Tools: Google Lighthouse, Meta Ad Library, Tableau Public, Excel

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01. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Project Overview

This project investigates how UK online grocery retailers can improve digital growth through better website experiences, paid advertising strategies, and data-driven experimentation.
The research combines three analytical workstreams:

1. Website Performance Intelligence: Ocado versus Sainsbury's.
2. Paid Social Creative Intelligence: Ocado versus Tesco.
3. Growth Opportunity Prioritisation: Ten proposed experiments across acquisition, website performance, checkout, and retention.

The objective is to move beyond reporting metrics and demonstrate how marketing intelligence can inform commercial decisions.

Research Scope

Area	Coverage
Retailers	Ocado, Sainsbury's, Tesco
Website pages audited	10
Meta advertisements analysed	10

Proposed growth experiments	10
Customer shopping missions	Weekly groceries, Dinner tonight
Analytical platform	Tableau Public
Data sources	Public websites and Meta Ad Library

Five Key Findings

01 — Ocado's audited pages showed substantial loading delays.
Ocado's five Lighthouse performance scores ranged from 32 to 37, with an average of 33.8.
02 — Sainsbury's performed better across the selected page sample.
Its five tested pages averaged 49.8, although page types were not fully matched.
03 — Search and basket performance emerged as investigation priorities.
Ocado's basket recorded an LCP of 28.8 seconds, while Sainsbury's milk search recorded 3,150 milliseconds of Total Blocking Time.
04 — Ocado and Tesco demonstrated different creative messaging mixes.
The selected Ocado ads emphasised value, discounts, and delivery offers. Tesco's sample included premium quality, recipe inspiration, Clubcard loyalty, and meal solutions.
05 — Ten growth experiments were proposed.
The highest ICE score was 7.33/10, assigned to improving Ocado's category-page experience.
Strategic conclusion: The strongest opportunity is to connect customer acquisition, digital experience improvements, and retention programmes through a measurable experimentation framework.

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02. BUSINESS PROBLEM & RESEARCH STRATEGY

The Business Challenge

Online grocery growth depends on more than advertising investment.
Retailers must attract customers, help them discover products, support basket completion, and encourage repeat purchases.
Potential growth barriers include:

- Slow product discovery.
- Poor mobile loading performance.

- Search and checkout friction.
- Overreliance on promotional advertising.
- Insufficient personalisation and retention activity.

This project examines observable signals related to these challenges.

Two Customer Shopping Missions

Mission A: Weekly Grocery Shopping

A customer wants to purchase everyday essentials efficiently.
Typical journey:
Category/Home → Search → Product → Basket → Checkout
Marketing considerations:
Search efficiency, product discovery, basket usability, and repeat purchasing.

Mission B: Dinner Tonight

A customer needs meal inspiration or a convenient dinner solution.
Typical journey:
Meal Inspiration → Search/Category → Product → Basket
Marketing considerations:
Recipe content, ready-meal discovery, convenience messaging, and relevant product recommendations.
These missions are analytical scenarios rather than observed customer sessions.

Why Different Brands Were Compared

Tesco's website could not be reliably tested because of an access restriction.
Therefore:

- Ocado vs Sainsbury's: Website performance benchmarking.
- Ocado vs Tesco: Paid social creative intelligence.

This preserves research integrity instead of manufacturing unavailable measurements.

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03. WEBSITE PERFORMANCE INTELLIGENCE

Methodology

Ten mobile Lighthouse observations were collected across publicly accessible grocery pages.
Metrics analysed:

Metric	Meaning

Performance Score	Lighthouse performance assessment, 0–100
FCP	First Contentful Paint
LCP	Largest Contentful Paint
TBT	Total Blocking Time
Speed Index	Visual loading progression
CLS	Cumulative Layout Shift

Lighthouse measures diagnostic page performance. It does not directly measure actual customer conversion or revenue.

Complete Lighthouse Results

Retailer	Page	Score	FCP	LCP	TBT	Speed Index
Ocado	Category	32	4.1s	31.5s	1,630ms	10.1s
Ocado	Prepared Meals Category	33	4.1s	24.6s	1,420ms	9.0s
Ocado	Milk Search	34	3.8s	24.7s	1,410ms	8.2s
Ocado	Basket	33	3.9s	28.8s	1,580ms	8.1s
Ocado	Prepared Meal Product	37	3.9s	11.4s	940ms	10.6s
Sainsbury's	Homepage	61	2.9s	10.6s	360ms	2.9s
Sainsbury's	Ready Meals Search	36	3.0s	8.8s	1,580ms	8.7s

Sainsbury's	Milk Product	56	2.0s	9.7s	670ms	3.0s
Sainsbury's	Login Page	54	12.1s	17.0s	130ms	12.1s
Sainsbury's	Milk Search	42	2.4s	9.4s	3,150ms	3.5s

All ten recorded CLS values were between 0 and 0.038.

Performance Comparison

Metric	Ocado Average	Sainsbury's Average
Performance Score	33.8	49.8
FCP	3.96s	4.48s
LCP	24.20s	11.10s
TBT	1,396ms	1,178ms
Speed Index	9.20s	6.04s

These are unweighted descriptive averages across different page selections, not controlled matched-page comparisons.

Key Finding 1: Ocado's Category Experience

Ocado's category page recorded:
Performance Score: 32/100
LCP: 31.5 seconds
TBT: 1,630 milliseconds
This was the highest LCP observed in the dataset.
Marketing implication: Slow category loading is a reasonable candidate for further investigation because category navigation supports product discovery.
Proposed action: Investigate above-the-fold image loading, JavaScript execution, and resource prioritisation.

Key Finding 2: Ocado's Basket Experience

Ocado's basket page recorded:
Performance Score: 33/100
LCP: 28.8 seconds
TBT: 1,580 milliseconds
Basket performance matters because customers may be approaching checkout.
Marketing implication: Basket speed could be relevant to checkout progression.
However, abandonment was not measured, so no conversion loss can be attributed to these results.

Key Finding 3: Sainsbury's Search Performance

Sainsbury's milk search page recorded:
TBT: 3,150 milliseconds
This was the highest TBT in the dataset.
Its ready-meals search page also achieved a relatively low performance score of 36.
Marketing implication: Search responsiveness deserves investigation, particularly for customers using search to discover products quickly.

Key Finding 4: Sainsbury's Homepage

Sainsbury's homepage achieved:
Performance Score: 61
FCP: 2.9 seconds
TBT: 360 milliseconds
It achieved the highest Lighthouse performance score in the selected sample.
However, its LCP was still 10.6 seconds.

Website Performance Recommendations

Priority 1: Investigate Ocado's category loading.
Repeat measurements, identify the LCP element, and assess feasible technical improvements.
Priority 2: Investigate Ocado's basket performance.
Measure whether technical changes improve the basket experience and checkout progression.
Priority 3: Investigate Sainsbury's search responsiveness.
Examine main-thread blocking and evaluate potential changes to product-result rendering.
Priority 4: Establish real-user performance monitoring.
Use field data and conversion events before estimating commercial impact.

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04. PAID SOCIAL CREATIVE INTELLIGENCE

Objective

Analyse how Ocado and Tesco communicate value through selected Meta advertisements.
The audit examined:

- Creative format.
- Messaging angle.
- Promotional offer.
- Estimated UK reach.
- Creative positioning.

Research Dataset

Five Ocado advertisements and five Tesco advertisements were manually analysed.
All ten were verified against the advertiser shown in Meta Ad Library.

Ocado Advertisements

Creative	Format	Messaging Angle	Estimated Reach
Swap It, Save It — Courgette Lasagne	Video	Value/Convenience	2,806,092
M&S Food — 25% Off + Free Delivery	Static	Discount	1,171,801
M&S Food — 25% Off + Free Delivery	Static	Discount	1,485,037
Free Delivery for 3 Months	Video	Free Delivery Trial	886,321
James Wellbeloved — £5 Coupon	Static	Petcare Health	17,167

Summed estimated ad reach: 6,366,418

Tesco Advertisements

Creative	Format	Messaging Angle	Estimated Reach

Tesco Finest Wines	Static	Premium Quality	9,236,044
Prawns Recipe	Video	Recipe Inspiration	2,825,610
Midweek Dinner Recipe	Video	Recipe Inspiration	2,223,250
Clubcard Prices	Carousel	Loyalty/Value	3,250,485
Naked Chicken Burrito Bowl	Video	Meal Solution	359,790

Summed estimated ad reach: 17,895,179
Combined summed estimated ad reach: 24,261,597
These are sums of individual ad-level reach estimates, not deduplicated unique audience totals. They should not be used to compare advertising effectiveness.

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05. CREATIVE STRATEGY ANALYSIS

Creative Format Mix

Reach-weighted composition of the ten selected ads:

Format	Ocado	Tesco
Video	58.0%	30.2%
Static	42.0%	51.6%
Carousel	0.0%	18.2%

Interpretation

Ocado
Video accounted for approximately 58% of summed estimated reach in the selected sample.
Its video examples included value messaging and a free-delivery trial.
Tesco

Static advertising accounted for approximately 52% of summed estimated reach.
The Tesco Finest wine advertisement contributed substantially to this figure.
Tesco also used recipe videos and Clubcard carousel advertising.
These differences describe the selected creatives, not either brand's complete media strategy.

Messaging Angle Mix

Ocado

Messaging Angle	Reach Share
Value/Convenience	44.1%
Discount	41.7%
Free Delivery Trial	13.9%
Petcare Health	0.3%

Tesco

Messaging Angle	Reach Share
Premium Quality	51.6%
Recipe Inspiration	28.2%
Loyalty/Value	18.2%
Meal Solution	2.0%

Promotional Offer Mix

Ocado

Offer	Reach Share
Discount + Free Delivery	41.7%
Free Delivery	13.9%
£5 Coupon	0.3%
Unknown/Unclassified	44.1%

Tesco

Offer	Reach Share
No Explicit Offer	81.8%
Clubcard Prices	18.2%

Three Strategic Insights

Insight 1 — Ocado: Value and Promotional Messaging

The Ocado sample prominently featured discounts, delivery incentives, and value-oriented creative.
Opportunity: Test whether convenience and meal inspiration messaging can attract qualified visitors alongside promotional advertising.

Insight 2 — Tesco: Product Quality and Recipe Inspiration

Tesco's sample combined premium product positioning, recipe-led content, and Clubcard value.
Opportunity: Investigate how different messaging angles perform across shopping missions.

Insight 3 — Creative Reach Does Not Equal Performance

High estimated reach does not prove stronger creative performance.
The dataset contains no advertising spend, click-through rates, conversion rates, or ROAS.
Recommendation: Use controlled creative experiments to assess qualified traffic, acquisition efficiency, and downstream conversions.

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06. GROWTH EXPERIMENT PRIORITISATION

Strategy

The project translates observed signals into ten proposed marketing and digital growth experiments.
Experiments were assessed using ICE scoring.
ICE = (Impact + Confidence + Ease) / 3
Each component uses a subjective 1–10 planning score.
A higher score indicates a more attractive proposal under the chosen assumptions, not a proven commercial return.

Complete Experiment Backlog

ID	Brand	Experiment	Primary KPI	ICE
EXP01	Ocado	Improve category loading	Category-to-Product CTR	7.33
EXP02	Ocado	Improve search rendering	Search-to-Product CTR	7.00
EXP03	Ocado	Improve basket performance	Basket-to-Checkout Rate	6.67
EXP04	Sainsbury's	Improve ready-meal search	Search-to-Product CTR	7.00
EXP05	Sainsbury's	Improve login journey messaging	Login Completion Rate	6.67
EXP06	Ocado	Recipe ads vs discount ads	Landing Page View Rate	6.67

EXP07	Tesco	Recipe video vs product creative	Landing Page View Rate	6.67
EXP08	Ocado	Test replenishment email timing	Second-Order Rate	6.33
EXP09	Sainsbury's	Test weekly basket reminders	Repeat Purchase Rate	6.33
EXP10	Ocado	Convenience vs discount messaging	Qualified Visit Rate	6.67

Detailed ICE Inputs

ID	Impact	Confidence	Ease	ICE
EXP01	9	8	5	7.33
EXP02	9	7	5	7.00
EXP03	9	7	4	6.67
EXP04	8	7	6	7.00
EXP05	8	5	7	6.67
EXP06	8	5	7	6.67
EXP07	7	5	8	6.67
EXP08	9	4	6	6.33
EXP09	8	4	7	6.33

EXP10	8	5	7	6.67

Original manually assigned classifications:

- High: EXP01, EXP02, EXP03, EXP04.
- Medium: EXP05–EXP10.

These labels were not assigned using a consistent numerical cutoff.

Highest-Ranked Experiment

EXP01 — Ocado Category Performance

ICE Score: 7.33/10
Observed evidence:

- Lighthouse performance score: 32.
- LCP: 31.5 seconds.
- TBT: 1,630 milliseconds.

Hypothesis: Improving category-page loading may increase customers' progression from category browsing to product discovery.
Proposed intervention: Investigate image delivery, script execution, and resource prioritisation.
Primary KPI: Category-to-product click-through rate.
Supporting metrics: LCP, engagement, and add-to-basket rate.
Success criteria: To be defined after obtaining baseline behavioural data and establishing the experiment's practical feasibility.

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07. PROPOSED 90-DAY GROWTH ROADMAP

The following is a recommended plan, not an implemented programme.

DAYS 1–30: DIAGNOSE & MEASURE

Objective: Validate observed issues and establish reliable performance baselines.
Recommended actions:

- Repeat Lighthouse measurements.
- Investigate slow category, search, and basket pages.
- Identify primary LCP elements.
- Establish customer journey event tracking.
- Measure baseline discovery and checkout progression.
- Define acquisition and retention KPIs.

Deliverable: Validated opportunity assessment and measurement plan.

DAYS 31–60: EXPERIMENT

Objective: Test the most promising opportunities.
Recommended experiments:
Website: Improve a selected high-friction page experience.
Paid Social: Compare recipe inspiration against promotional messaging.
Customer Acquisition: Test convenience messaging against percentage discounts.
CRM: Pilot replenishment reminder timing with appropriate consent and customer data.
Deliverable: Controlled experiments with documented hypotheses and KPIs.

DAYS 61–90: EVALUATE & PRIORITISE

Objective: Evaluate results and decide which initiatives merit further investment.
Recommended actions:

- Analyse experiment outcomes.
- Estimate incremental commercial impact where data permits.
- Review implementation costs.
- Identify successful creative approaches.
- Refine CRM targeting.
- Update the experiment backlog.

Deliverable: Evidence-based recommendations for scaling, iteration, or stopping initiatives.

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08. DATA VISUALISATION & DASHBOARDS

Four analytical dashboard components were developed using Tableau Public.

Dashboard 01 — Mobile Performance Benchmark

Purpose: Compare mobile Lighthouse results across Ocado and Sainsbury's.
Key analyses:

- Performance scores.
- LCP.
- TBT.
- Page-type comparisons.
- Weekly versus dinner shopping scenarios.

View Tableau Dashboard

Dashboard 02 — Website Performance Bottlenecks

Purpose: Identify pages requiring deeper technical investigation.
Visualisations:

- LCP versus TBT scatterplot.

- LCP by page type.
- TBT by page type.
- Reference-line analysis.

Dashboard 03 — Paid Social Creative Intelligence

Purpose: Compare Ocado and Tesco creative strategies.
Visualisations:

- Reach-weighted format mix.
- Messaging angle mix.
- Promotional offer mix.
- Advertisement-level table.
- Interactive filtering.

View Tableau Dashboard

Dashboard 04 — Growth Experiment Prioritisation

Purpose: Organise proposed growth initiatives using ICE scoring.
Visualisations:

- Impact versus Ease matrix.
- Confidence-sized bubbles.
- Experiment leaderboard.
- Brand filters.
- Customer journey filters.

View Tableau Dashboard

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09. FINAL MARKETING RECOMMENDATIONS

Recommendation 1 — Prioritise Customer Journey Performance

Investigate slow page experiences before assuming additional advertising investment will solve growth challenges.
Initial focus: Ocado's category, search, and basket pages.

Recommendation 2 — Develop Mission-Based Creative Testing

Organise messaging around customer needs rather than relying on a single creative approach.
Weekly shopping: Value, convenience, and essentials.
Dinner tonight: Recipes, inspiration, and easy meal solutions.

Recommendation 3 — Evaluate Promotional Dependence

Test whether non-discount messaging can attract qualified traffic efficiently.
This does not mean promotions should be removed; their incremental value should be measured.

Recommendation 4 — Connect Acquisition With Retention

Develop measurable retention experiments such as replenishment reminders and weekly shopping prompts.
Assess performance through second-order and repeat purchase rates.

Recommendation 5 — Establish a Continuous Experimentation Framework

Use a repeatable process:
Research → Diagnose → Prioritise → Experiment → Measure → Improve
This allows marketing teams to connect insights with decisions rather than treating dashboards as standalone reporting outputs.

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10. LIMITATIONS & RESEARCH INTEGRITY

This project is an independent analysis using publicly available information.

Website Performance

The Lighthouse dataset contains ten manually collected observations.
Results are not representative of all devices, customers, or browsing conditions.
The website comparison uses different page mixes.

Paid Social

The Meta analysis includes ten selected advertisements.
Estimated reach is not equivalent to clicks, conversions, or revenue.
Summed reach does not represent a deduplicated audience.
The creative sample is not representative of either advertiser's complete media strategy.

Growth Experiments

The ten experiments are proposals.
No experiments were implemented on the retailers' websites.
ICE scores represent subjective assessments.

No actual conversion uplift, incremental revenue, ROAS, or customer lifetime value was measured.

Attribution

This work is not affiliated with or endorsed by Ocado, Sainsbury's, Tesco, or Meta.

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11. SKILLS & BUSINESS CAPABILITIES DEMONSTRATED

Competency	Project Evidence
Marketing Analytics	Lighthouse and Meta datasets
Competitor Intelligence	Three-retailer research framework
Performance Marketing	Creative angle and offer analysis
Digital Experience	Page-performance benchmarking
Data Visualisation	Tableau Public dashboards
Customer Journey Analysis	Weekly and dinner missions
Growth Strategy	Ten proposed experiments
Experimentation	Hypotheses, ICE scores, KPIs
CRM Strategy	Replenishment and basket reminders
Business Communication	Strategic insights and 90-day roadmap

FINAL PROJECT CONCLUSION

From Marketing Data to Growth Decisions

The UK Online Grocery Growth Intelligence project demonstrates how publicly available data can be transformed into an actionable marketing strategy framework.
The research identified potential website-performance investigation priorities, highlighted differences in selected paid social creative approaches, and translated those observations into ten proposed growth experiments.
The work does not claim to have generated revenue improvements or proved causal business effects.
Instead, its value lies in demonstrating a repeatable analytical process that connects technical diagnostics, marketing intelligence, customer journey thinking, and structured experimentation.

Project Outcome

10 website observations. 10 paid social advertisements. 10 growth experiments. 4 Tableau dashboard components. 1 integrated growth intelligence framework.
Core capability demonstrated:
Turning fragmented marketing data into clear insights, measurable hypotheses, and prioritised business recommendations.